



# { LEARN PROGRAMMING WITH CODE::BLOCKS } ON WINDOWS

This is an introduction to a free and open source IDE — Code::Blocks, which is basically a C/C++ IDE that supports a couple of compilers.

The Integrated Development Environment (IDE) is an application that can convert the mundane task of writing hundreds of lines of code into a colourful process. It is a productivity tool that increases the efficiency of the programmer. IDEs are generally a combination of a compiler, a code editor and a debugger. One of the most important features of IDEs is that they are 'intelligent' enough to identify and auto complete keywords and syntaxes, thereby reducing the errors due to typos. One of the first IDEs was made for Dartmouth BASIC. It was a command line-based IDE and had little resemblance to its modern day avatar. In 1975, Maestro 1, a product from Softlab Munich, became the world's first Integrated Development Environment for software. It was a big hit till the 1980s.

Today, we have no shortage of IDEs. Choosing the right IDE for your work can be confusing when the options before you are many. Code::Blocks is available on Linux, Windows and Mac platforms. But I will be dealing with Code::Blocks for the Windows platform. Things are pretty much the same on Linux too, except for the installation part (as I have never used a Mac, I cannot comment on that platform).

The first stable release of Code::Blocks was in February 2008 and it had a version scheme 8.02 (*year.month* of release). The latest stable version of Code::Blocks is 12.11. It supports multiple compilers, including MinGW/GCC, Digital Mars, Microsoft Visual C++, Borland C++, Watcom, LCC and the Intel C++ compiler.

## Installing Code::Blocks

When you visit the downloads page of Code::Blocks, <http://www.Code::Blocks.org/downloads/26#windows>, you will find four options. Identifying the correct package is your first task. I will explain the binaries that are available for Windows, but the same options are available for Linux and Mac platforms too.

1. *Code::Blocks -12.11-setup.exe*—This package contains just Code::Blocks and does not have the compilers. This is suitable for those who already have any one of the supported compilers on their system. It is just a 28.2 MB package.
2. *Code::Blocks -12.11-setup\_user.exe*—This package is the same as the earlier one but is for people using systems to which they have no admin rights.
3. *Code::Blocks -12.11mingw-setup.exe*—This package is a complete set with Code::Blocks and the GCC compiler. It is like a fresh install. Beginners will find this convenient, although it is a 96.8 MB package to download.
4. *Code::Blocks -12.11mingw-setup\_user.exe*—Again, this is the same as the one above but is for users who have no admin rights on their system.

Once you have identified the package you require, downloading it and installing it is quite easy. Just follow the instructions on the installation wizard. For Packages 1 and 2, which do not include the compiler, once installed, Code::Blocks automatically looks for the compiler.